

FLORA RUSTICA

Exhibiting accurate figures of such plants
as are either useful or injurious in husbandry.

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ADVERTISEMENT

The design of this work is to figure and describe such plants as the farmer is chiefly interested in knowing; whether because they are useful to him in husbandry, or because they are hurtful to his cattle, or troublesome weeds among his crops.

The figures are drawn from nature, and coloured after the life. The descriptions are short, and in English; the terms of art being avoided as much as the subject would permit.

MEADOW FOX-TAIL GRASS

Alopecurus pratensis. Linn.

Of all our grasses this is one of the earliest, and most productive. It delights in a moist and fertile meadow, and shoots forth its spike before the end of April. The culm rises to two feet or more; the spike is soft, and resembles the tail of a fox, whence the trivial name.

Cattle of every kind eat it greedily. It is recommended for laying down meadow land intended to be mown early.

COMMON BROOM

Spartium scoparium. Linn.

The Broom grows wild upon dry gravelly and sandy soils in most parts of England. It flowers in May and June, the blossoms of a full yellow, large and conspicuous.

Sheep are said to eat the young tops in winter when other green food fails; but taken in quantity they are hurtful. The twigs serve for besoms, and the old wood for fuel.

CHARLOCK

Sinapis arvensis. Linn.

A most troublesome weed among spring corn, known by its rough leaves and yellow cruciform flowers. One plant will ripen many hundred seeds, which lie long in the ground and vegetate when brought near the surface by the plough.

The only remedies are hand-weeding while the corn is young, and fallowing the land in a dry summer.

MEADOW SAFFRON

Colchicum autumnale. Linn.

The Meadow Saffron sends up its purple flowers naked from the ground in September; the leaves and seed-vessel appear not till the spring following.

The root is a solid bulb, and with the whole plant is acrid and poisonous. Cattle commonly refuse the leaves; but instances are recorded of cows being killed by eating them among the grass.

WHITE OR DUTCH CLOVER

Trifolium repens. Linn.

This valuable little plant is found in almost every pasture, and makes the finest and sweetest feed for sheep. The stalks creep and strike root at every joint, whereby it soon covers the ground and forms a close turf.

It is sown with the other grasses in laying land down, at the rate of five or six pounds to the acre.

COMMON NIGHTSHADE

Solanum nigrum. Linn.

A weed of gardens, dunghills and waste places, flowering from June till the frosts. The berries are black when ripe, and, like the whole plant, are to be suspected: children should be warned against them.

It is an annual, easily destroyed by the hoe before the seed is perfected.

RAGWORT

Senecio jacobaea. Linn.

Ragwort abounds in neglected pastures, rising with the flowering stem to two or three feet, crowned with a corymb of yellow flowers in July and August.

Horses and cows leave it standing, whence a pasture overrun with it wears an air of great slovenliness. Frequent mowing before the seed ripens, and folding sheep upon the land, subdue it.

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